

Faith That Endures: A Small Group Study on Hebrews 11

By Marcus Bell

This three-session study walks through one of the great chapters on faith. Each session includes a short reading, a few observations, and questions for discussion. Plan on about an hour per session.

Session 1: What Faith Is

Begin by reading Hebrews 11:1 aloud: "Now faith is assurance of things hoped for, proof of things not seen." The writer is not describing a vague feeling. Faith rests on the character of God, who has proven himself trustworthy again and again.

It also helps to notice what faith is not. People sometimes say they have faith in the stock market, or faith that their team will finally win this season, but that kind of faith is really just a hopeful guess about the future. Biblical faith is different, because it is anchored in a person rather than a prediction.

The writer goes further in Heb. 11:6, explaining that pleasing God requires faith, since anyone who comes to God has to believe that he is real and that he is a rewarder of those who seek him.

Discussion questions:

1. How would you explain the difference between faith and optimism?
2. What is one thing you are trusting God for that you cannot yet see?

Session 2: Faith Under Testing

One of the hardest stories in Scripture is the day God tested Abraham. Abraham was told to take Isaac, the son he loved and the child of promise, up a mountain and offer him as a sacrifice. Abraham rose early, made the long journey, and built the altar. When Isaac asked where the lamb was, his father answered that God would provide the lamb. Just as Abraham raised the knife, the angel of the LORD called out and stopped him, and Abraham saw a ram caught in the thicket by his horns.

Before your group meets, read all of Genesis 22 slowly. Notice how few words Abraham speaks, and how much trust is packed into each one.

Discussion questions:

1. What do you think was going through Abraham's mind on the walk up the mountain?
2. When has obeying God cost you something that mattered to you?

Session 3: Faith That Holds On

Paul looks back at Abraham in Romans 4:20-21 and says that he "didn't waver through unbelief, but grew strong through faith, giving glory to God." Abraham was completely sure that God was able to keep his word. His faith was not strong because Abraham was strong. It was strong because he kept looking at the promise instead of at his circumstances.

Close your study by praying for one another, especially for anyone in your group who is still waiting on a promise.

Discussion questions:

1. What helps you keep your eyes on God's promises when circumstances look discouraging?
2. Who in your life has shown you what steady faith looks like?